

Dendrelaphis kopsteini

Kopstein's bronzeback snake



Length 5 ft (1.5 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial/Arboreal
Status Least concern

Location S.E. Asia



Bronzebacks are arboreal, day-active snakes, named for the bright iridescent sheen of their upper body scales. Thought to be most closely related to the Southeast Asian flying snakes, this

species, described in the year 2007, is also known for the bright, brick-red color of its neck, which flares when it expands its neck. It was previously confused with allied species and is known to occur in rain forests throughout Thailand, the Malay peninsula, Singapore, and Sumatra. Like many other bronzebacks, it mainly preys on tree-dwelling lizards, such as geckos, and perhaps frogs.



Boiga dendrophila

Mangrove snake



Length 6½–8¼ ft (2–2.5 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Not evaluated

Location S.E. Asia



The mangrove snake is mainly glossy black, with vibrant yellow markings on its lips and flanks—these vivid colors may act as a warning to predators. Its body is slightly flattened from side to side, and a distinct ridge runs down the center of its back. If threatened,

the mangrove snake draws back its flattened head in readiness to strike, and flares its yellow lip scales. A stealthy nocturnal hunter, this snake preys on lizards, frogs, birds, and small mammals. During the day, it rests in the crook of a tree, or remains coiled among foliage. Females lay 4–15 eggs in leaf litter, rotting stumps, or tree holes.



Bogertophis subocularis

Trans-Pecos ratsnake



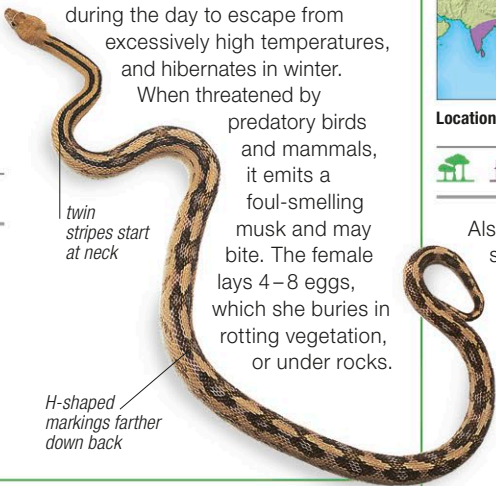
Length 3¼–4¼ ft (1–1.3 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S. USA, N.E. Mexico



North America is home to a number of ratsnake species, all of them slender-bodied predators that hunt after dark. The Trans-Pecos ratsnake is typical in having variable patterning: one form has large, H-shaped markings, while another—the “blond” form—has paler, circular blotches. Where their

distributions overlap, these 2 forms interbreed. Large, prominent eyes indicate that this species is entirely nocturnal. This secretive snake shelters in cracks and under slabs during the day to escape from excessively high temperatures, and hibernates in winter. When threatened by predatory birds and mammals, it emits a foul-smelling musk and may bite. The female lays 4–8 eggs, which she buries in rotting vegetation, or under rocks.



Chrysopelea ornata

Golden flying snake



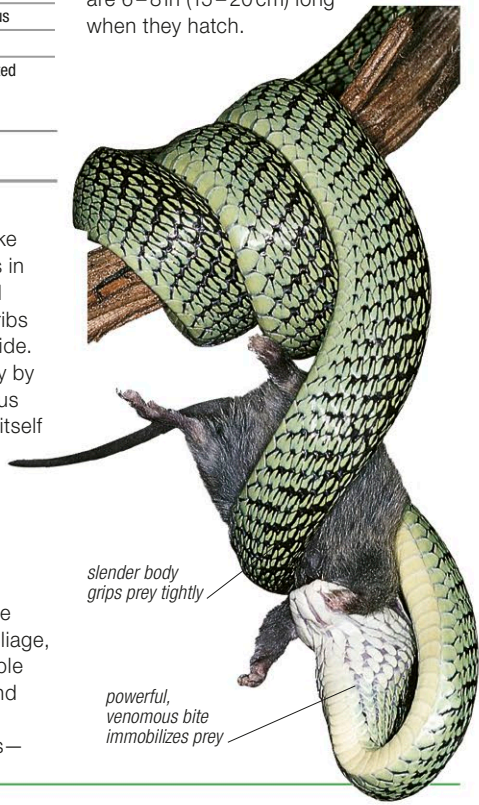
Length 3¼–4¼ ft (1–1.3 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Not evaluated

Location S. and S.E. Asia



Also known as the golden tree snake, the golden flying snake can glide among high trees in tropical forests, parks, and gardens, by spreading its ribs to form a concave underside. When threatened—usually by birds of prey or carnivorous mammals—it may launch itself from a high perch in order to escape; if cornered, it will bite. It has a slender body, with green, black-tipped scales, and a narrow head with large eyes. The male has a longer, thicker tail than the female. The golden flying snake frequently rests in trees, among foliage, but always remains alert for possible prey. An active hunter, it grasps and holds its victims—generally small mammals, birds, lizards, and frogs—

until the venom takes effect. Although it has a powerful bite, this rear-fanged snake is not particularly harmful to humans. Females lay 6–14 eggs in soil, leaf litter, or rotting wood. The young are 6–8 in (15–20 cm) long when they hatch.



Dasypeltis scabra

Common egg-eating snake



Length 28–39 in (70–100 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location Africa and W. Asia



Many snakes eat soft-shelled reptile eggs, but this nocturnal African snake specializes in eating the hard-shelled eggs of birds. It feeds heavily during the bird breeding season—swallowing its food whole—and then fasts for the rest of the year. This species and its close relatives are the only snakes that do not have teeth.

A DIET OF EGGS



The very flexible skull, mouth, and throat enable this snake to eat eggs. When an egg reaches the throat, projections of the snake's backbone saw through the shell, which is regurgitated.



MIMICKING THE VIPER

This snake mimics the saw-scaled viper (see p.403) by forming a horseshoe-shaped coil and rubbing the strongly keeled scales on its flanks together, making a rasping sound.

Hierophis viridiflavus

European whipsnake



Length 5 ft (1.5 m), rarely 6½ ft (2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S. Europe



Also called the western whipsnake, this slender, large-eyed snake is usually greenish yellow, but may be totally black. The young are more brightly colored than the adults. A fast-moving and agile hunter, it relies largely on sight while

hunting lizards, rodents, and smaller snakes. When attacked, it is quick to escape into holes and crevices, and may bite viciously. Several individuals may share a den, resulting in a dense population. Females lay 6–14 eggs in soil, leaf litter, or rotting wood.

